seem counterintuitive at first. However, this approach isn't as unusual as it might seem.

ACME already depends on context signals that originate from devices employees use in various locations and on untrusted networks. While ACME controls and manages these devices, the employees hold and operate them. An example of this is *device posture attestation*, where the device assesses its own security status and sends a signed token to ACME when the employee accesses ACME systems. As discussed in chapter 2, ACME's confidence in this signal comes from cryptographic protections that prevent tampering and enable ACME to verify that the token was generated by trusted hardware or software. Trust, on the other hand, is placed in the organization that developed the attestation software and on ACME's own processes for installing, configuring, and managing it on employee devices. Verifiable credentials follow the same principle: a holder can store and present a credential, but ACME's confidence in the credential stems from the issuer's signature and cryptographic protocols, while its trust is based on the issuer's authority to make the claims it contains.

A verifiable credential is best understood as a cryptographic container for attributes. The issuer writes a set of claims about a subject, such as employment status, a professional license, or authorization to act on behalf of a company. These claims are assembled into a credential, signed by the issuer, and given to the subject to hold. The subject can present this credential to ACME when requesting access. ACME can verify the signature to ensure that the claims have not been changed and that they were issued by an authorized entity. In this way, attributes travel with the person yet remain linked to the issuer's authority.